the casual observer. He views the natural world as something vast, asymmetrical, and constantly shifting. This fluidity is why he chooses not to paint a literal scene, but rather to create an entirely new work inspired by a specific location. "While the painting originates from that place, it eventually becomes something else entirely," he explains.

Singh's landscapes are notably devoid of human figures, a deliberate choice that invites the viewer into the frame. He believes that by leaving the canvas open, every onlooker can imagine themselves within the environment. By taking a physical spot and reimagining it on canvas, he transcends the original location. "In a sense," he says, "I have expanded nature by giving a single spot a new, unlimited form."

Even after six decades, the Delhi School of Art alumnus remains a dedicated student of his craft, approaching his canvas with the discipline of *riyaaz*. "I am not a sentimental painter," he chuckles, adding that there is no wait for inspiration to strike for him to pick up his brush. Singh's work continues to transcend specific geography—he may start with a memory of a forest but might finish with a sky of "courageous pinks" that exist only in his mind. By distilling nature into its purest essence, Singh continues to offer viewers an invitation to wander through landscapes that are entirely new, yet deeply familiar—a testament to an artist who doesn't just replicate the world but generously expands it. ■

—Deepali Dhingra

Liminal Geographies *is on view at Vadehra Art Gallery till Apr. 2*

ART ▼

Republic Illustrated

A NEW EXHIBITION IN MUMBAI EXPLORES HOW NANDALAL BOSE'S ART CAPTURED THE SPIRIT OF A NATION IN THE MAKING

At the behest of Mahatma Gandhi, Nandalal Bose put brush to paper to create a landmark moment in modern Indian art. The Haripura Panels of 1938, created for the Indian National Congress session at Haripura (Gujarat), are remarkable works that celebrate the vitality of rural India. Rendered in bold lines and luminous colours inspired by folk traditions, they depict farmers, potters, artisans, musicians and women at work. They are now on display at Mumbai's National Gallery of Modern Art (NGMA) as part of the exhibition *Colours of Swades: From Haripura to the Constitution*.

A disciple of Abanindranath Tagore and later the first principal of Kala Bhavana at Santiniketan, Bose believed that Indian art must grow from its own soil. Nidhi Choudhari, director of NGMA Mumbai, says: "Nandalal Bose occupies a foundational place in the story of Indian modern art. Instead of borrowing from Western academic traditions, he drew inspiration from Ajanta murals, folk traditions, temple sculpture and the rhythms of everyday rural life. He created a visual language rooted in Indian civilisation, yet profoundly modern in its expression." Each panel is accompanied by a QR code, which when scanned, immerses the viewer into an AI-assisted animation created by Mumbai-based filmmaker Ebyug Akhil. This digital interpretation brings the panels to life, offering audiences a more experiential way to engage with the art.

THE EXHIBITION ALSO EXPLORES BOSE'S ROLE IN DEFINING THE VISUAL AESTHETICS OF THE MANUSCRIPT OF INDIA'S CONSTITUTION

The exhibition also explores Bose's role in defining the visual aesthetics of the manuscript of the Constitution of India. Along with his students at Kala Bhavana, he designed the decorative borders and illustrations that frame the text. Through these images, he evoked India's civilisational journey, drawing on visual references from the Indus Valley civilisation, scenes from the Ramayana, moments from the Mughal era and stories from the freedom movement. ■

—Prachi Joshi

The exhibition is on view at NGMA Mumbai until Apr. 9



▲ **A MASTERLY NOTE** 'Veena Vadini' by Nandalal Bose